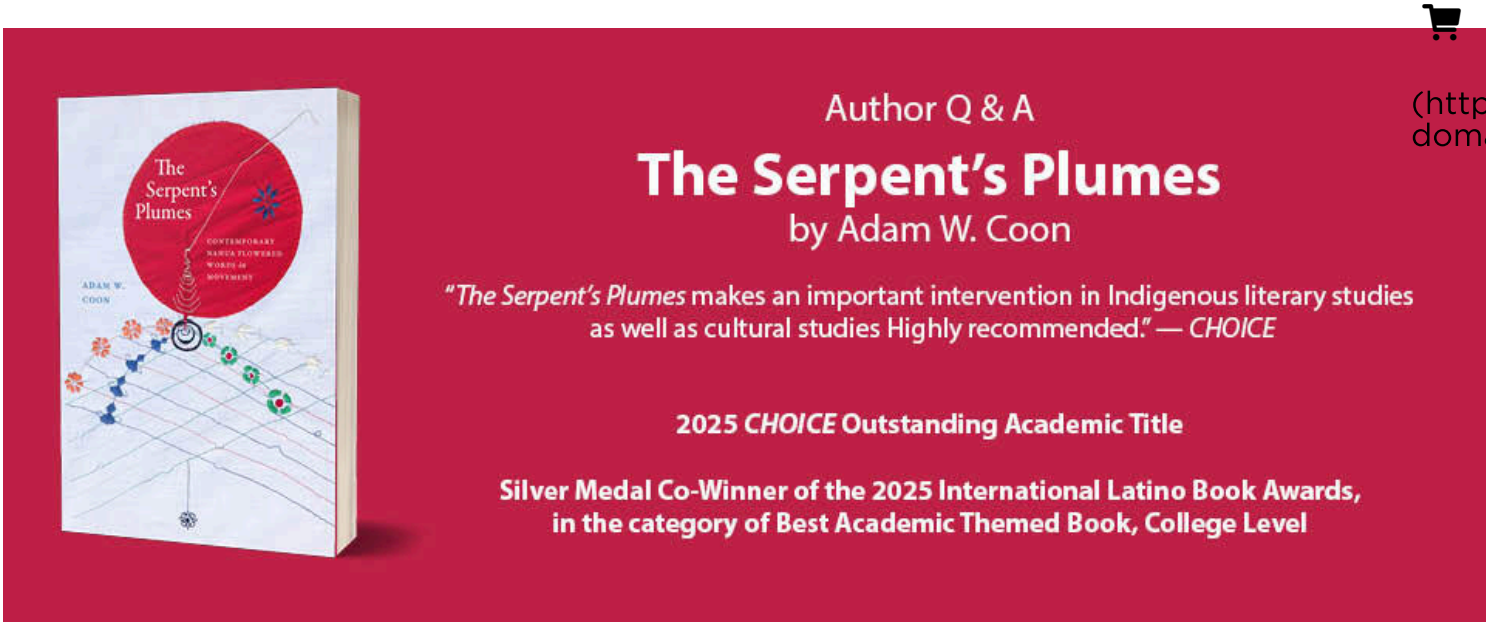


Making the Word Flourish: A Conversation on Nahua Literature, Activism, and Living Knowledge

One-to-One with Adam W. Coon, author of The Serpent's Plumes

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Nahua literature is not a relic of the past—it is a vibrant, evolving body of thought that continues to shape cultural, political, and intellectual life across Indigenous communities today. In *The Serpent's Plumes* (/Books/T/The-Serpent-s-Plumes2), Adam W. Coon invites readers to rethink how Nahua concepts, languages, and worldviews illuminate both historical continuities and contemporary struggles.

In this One-to-One Author Q&A, Coon reflects on the profound influence of Nahua epistemologies such as *ixtlamatilistli* (face knowledge), *yoltlajlamikilistli* (affective intelligence), and *tlaixpan* (the past before us) on their research. They discuss the flourishing of modern *xochitlajtoli* (flowered words), the political force of Indigenous languages, and the responsibilities that come with writing about living traditions.

What emerges is a portrait of Nahua literature as cultural activism—rooted in ancestral knowledge, responsive to present-day realities, and boldly charting new paths for future generations.

Q: Your book centers Nahua concepts such as *ixtlamatilistli*, *yoltlajlamikilistli*, and *tlaixpan* as analytical frameworks. How did these concepts shape your own research process, and what challenges did you encounter when translating them for non-Nahua readers?

A: When I started studying Nahua literatures nearly twenty years ago, the mainstream academic theories I learned in graduate school felt increasingly inadequate. They just couldn't fully capture Nahua contexts and struggles. Tlaixpan, the Nahuatl word for altar, was a pivotal example. It showed how much their view of the past *being in front* is deeply connected to objects and practices. Literally "what's in front," altars hold

images of deceased relatives. They are placed *in front*, unlike how *passed* and *pasado* denote something *behind* us in English and Spanish. This insight became the anchor for the entire research project, leading me to root it in Nahua concepts instead of foisting outside theories on Nahua literatures.

I remember collaborating with Huastecan Nahua initiatives in 2009, eager to share—or honestly, impose—all the theoretical perspectives from my grad studies, such as conceptualizations of cultural hybridity. Dialogues truly began to take off only after I committed to thinking *through* Nahua concepts like tlaixpan. Nahua writer Natalio Hernández and Nahua artist Eneida Hernández were key in leading this change. They directed meetings focused on intensely discussing the profound meanings of Nahuatl words and phrases for hours—an activity they called tijxochiyotisej tlajtoli, or "we will make the word flourish."

Within these conversations, the concepts of ixtlamatilistli (face knowledge), yoltlajlamikilistli (affective intelligence), and tlaixpan continually arose, both as subjects of discussion and as demonstrated forms of experiential knowledges and affective intelligence that shaped how discussions were run. Translating this complexity for non-Nahua audiences often requires paragraphs to explain meanings contained in words and short phrases. This approach shapes my current research on Nahua pedagogies, and the practice of "making the word flourish" is the guiding structure for my new book focused on Nahua activism in education.

Q: Contemporary Nahua writers are often overshadowed by the canon of colonial-era Nahuatl poetry. What do you hope readers will understand about the vitality and innovation of modern xochitlajtoli after reading *The Serpent's Plumes*?

A: Yes, that's so true; most people immediately think of the great Nahua-Texcoco poet Nezahualcoyotl. This often ends up being a double-edged sword: Nahuatl gets special attention, but it's attention that tries to chain flowered Nahua words to some distant past. When Carol Ann Duffy writes

poetry, people aren't expecting her to constantly allude to Shakespeare's sonnets or demanding to know where Shakespeare is in her work. But, oddly enough, that's often the case when Nahuas write. It can create a real love-hate dynamic with the works of Nezahualcoyotl and other Classical Nahuatl authors. Authors *do* reference Nezahualcoyotl, but at the same time, A LOT has happened in the last five centuries. They often riff on major figures like Nezahualcoyotl and Quetzalcoatl, adapting them into their own orthographies (Nesaualkoyotl) and, crucially, into contemporary contexts.

The title, *The Serpent's Plumes*, is inspired by Mardonio Carballo two-decade radio program, *Las Plumas de la Serpiente*. He inverted the romanticized figure of Quetzalcoatl, The Feathered Serpent, to make a point: that Nahuas and other Indigenous Nations are writing *today*, showcasing incredible diversity and innovative styles—and *plumas* means both a writing quill and feathers. That's precisely why "contemporary" is in the title. My hope is that reading *The Serpent's Plumes: Contemporary Nahua Flowered Words in Movement* sparks a desire in readers to seek out contemporary Indigenous literatures. I see *The Serpent's Plumes* as more of a signpost pointing toward this literary production.

Q: You describe Nahua literature as a form of cultural activism. Can you share an example from your research of how a particular poet or text embodies resistance to racism, marginalization, or patriarchal structures?

A: There are so many compelling examples. Ateri Miyawatl composed her poem "Neijmantototsintle" (Sorrowsongbird) during a period of immense regional turmoil. Her writing delves into how to process trauma. Significantly, she is first and foremost an activist; she essentially *walked* into poetry because of that activism. She experienced traumatic events firsthand, eventually having to flee her own hometown after joining protests against the horrifying killing of 43 students from Ayotzinapa, Guerrero, in 2014. Here are the opening lines of "Neijmantototsintle," featuring a songbird as the embodiment of sorrow:

Ken se tototl ejko neijmantle

patlantikisa niman notlalia ipan noyojlo

notik chanchiwa

ompa nokwikacha, kolintika iakoko,

kiminitocha ikxitsiwan

Sorrow arrives like a songbird

he swoops suddenly and alights on my heart

and nests inside

singing there, his throat trills,

dancing his little feet

The poetic persona works through trauma by means of this encounter in the closing lines:

ijke kuak neijmantototsintle netsatlapalowa

nejwa san nikaki, san ni yolyemania

san ni tsinpolake itik tlajle

san nixtololxochiameya

kuak onsiewe tototsintle, kuajon yo

patlane wejka

niman netskatewa nixochipontok

netskatewa nixochipontok yejwin tototsintle

when the sorrowsongbird visits

I only listen, only heart-soften

only join the earth

only spring like flowers in my eyes

when the little bird tires, then

he flies far

and leaves me as I bloom

that little bird leaves me as I bloom

Through their literature, many Nahua authors combat racism, marginalization, and patriarchal structures. As Ayuujk theorist Yásnaya Elena Aguilar Gil states, Indigenous languages carry political weight and must not be treated as something "merely cultural." This clear thread of activism is likewise found in the works of additional writers, including Mardonio Carballo, Araceli Patlani, Natalio Hernández, Ethel Xochitiotzin Pérez, and Martín Tonalmeyotl.

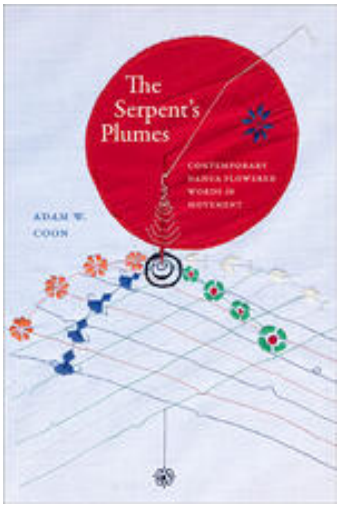
Q: The idea of *tlaixpan*—the past lying ahead of us—is compelling. How does this temporal worldview transform our understanding of Indigenous literary continuity from the precolonial past into the present?

A: While precolonial and colonial texts certainly influence contemporary literature, authors' grandparents and great-grandparents are more salient. Natalio Hernández's pseudonym, José Antonio Xokoyotsin, is a direct homage to his grandfather (and *not* the sixteenth-century Mexica tlahtoani Motecuhzoma Xocoyotzin). The concept of tlaixpan overturns the tendency to relegate contemporary Indigenous peoples to a distant past, instead quite literally bringing the past to the forefront. This is especially pressing for Nahuatl due to the common romanticization of older Nahua literatures. Tlaixpan aligns closely with the perspective of seven generations shared by many Native Nations, meaning present-day decisions must consider the effects on seven generations of both descendants *and* ancestors.

Q: As a scholar working closely with Nahua communities and authors, how do you navigate your role as both an academic interpreter and an advocate for Indigenous knowledge systems? What responsibilities come with writing about living Indigenous traditions?

A: I believe one of the principal challenges is distance, both physical and conceptual. Within academia, it's vital to advocate for these Nahua perspectives so they aren't seen just as *topics* to study, but as *theoretical frameworks* we use to conduct research. That presents an immense challenge within a system historically designed to marginalize these very viewpoints. We need to shift from just saying "*oh, that's interesting*" to genuinely applying these ideas—not solely within Nahua contexts and Indigenous Studies, but across a wide array of fields. What if we were to apply these perspectives in environmental studies or anthropology? One of the responsibilities inherent in writing about these topics is recognizing how much is at stake, and amplifying Nahua voices defending their territory in a broad sense, encompassing land, language strengthening programs, mass media, and *comunalidad*, which is a political system rooted in deep reciprocity.

Books Mentioned In This Post



The Serpent's Plumes Contemporary Nahua Flowered Words in Movement

(/Books/T/The-Serpent-s-Plumes2)

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